

Holding Pattern

Spot wrong answers, protect your privacy, and see scams coming

— FIVE SCAMS, ONE MOTOR

The scam	The tell	The defence
Voice clone	A call that sounds exactly like family: in trouble, needing money urgently and secretly.	Hang up. Call back on the number you already have. Agree a family safe word.
Romance scam	A warm companion who never quite meets you. Then a crisis, and a request for money.	Never send money to someone you haven't met. Tell one trusted person.
Fake invoice	An email that looks exactly like your bank, telco or builder: 'updated bank details'.	Phone the company on the number you already have, never the one in the email.
Deepfake video	A famous face urging you into an investment platform. It is manufactured.	Any video urging you to move money is a scam until proven otherwise.
Urgency engine	The motor inside all of them: act now, keep it secret, don't hang up.	Urgency is the tell. 'I'll call you back tomorrow' defeats almost every scam.

— TRUST, VERIFY, OR WALK AWAY

TRUST when stakes are low and the job is shaping: drafts, wording, plans, ideas. Most of your week; no checking needed.

VERIFY when you'll act on it: any fact, price, date or rule gets the rule of two. Money, health and legal calls add a qualified human.

WALK AWAY the moment you feel the urgency engine. Legitimate things survive a pause. Nothing real is ruined by 'I'll call you back tomorrow'.

— NEVER, EVER SHARE

Passwords and PINs · full bank or card numbers · tax file, Medicare, passport and licence numbers · other people's personal details.

The postcard test: would you write it on a postcard to a stranger? When torn, leave it out.

— IF SOMETHING GETS THROUGH

No shame, fast action. Call your bank first: it can sometimes stop or recall transfers. Then report to **Scamwatch** (scamwatch.gov.au) and, for identity worries, **IDCARE** (idcare.org). Tell someone you trust.

✈ CLEARED TO TRY

Run three trust tests on your tool: ask about something you know deeply and find the error; ask for a fact with sources and check one; try a false premise and see if it corrects you. Then **agree the family safe word** this week.